

Knowledge Freshness, Supersession, and Source Withdrawal Policy

Version control, active-index eligibility, emergency withdrawal, and citation continuity

Document ID	Version	Effective	Review due
NB-RAG-002	1.0	2026-08-17	2027-08-17

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Owner: Knowledge Governance Lead
Approved by: Fictional Clinical Governance Committee
Classification: Training / synthetic corpus

Document control and retrieval metadata

Field	Value
Canonical title	Knowledge Freshness, Supersession, and Source Withdrawal Policy
Document ID	NB-RAG-002
Keywords	freshness, superseded, withdrawn, version, reindex, citation, source lifecycle
Authority	Knowledge Governance Lead
Applicability	Training simulations only
Relationship	Standalone extension; existing corpus documents remain unchanged

Retrieval rule

Retrieve when documents differ, review dates pass, source status is uncertain, or corpus/index changes are proposed.

1. Source lifecycle

Status	Search eligibility	Meaning
DRAFT	No	Not approved
ACTIVE	Yes	Approved current version within applicability
REVIEW_DUE	Conditional	Visible to governance; clinical use only under defined temporary approval
SUPERSEDED	No	Replaced by newer version; retained for audit
WITHDRAWN	No	Removed urgently due to safety, legal, quality, or provenance concern
ARCHIVED	No	Historical record only

2. Mandatory metadata

- Document ID, canonical title, version, status, owner, approver, effective date, review date, jurisdiction, audience, source URL/file identity, content hash, ingestion timestamp, withdrawal/supersession link, and synthetic flag.
- Chunk metadata must inherit document status and version; a chunk cannot remain active after its parent is withdrawn.
- The index must filter eligibility before similarity ranking.

3. Supersession workflow

Step	Control
Approve	New document receives unique version and effective date
Link	New version identifies superseded version; old version becomes non-searchable
Ingest	Create chunks/embeddings with content hash and metadata
Validate	Run retrieval, citation, conflict and regression checks
Activate	Switch eligibility atomically where possible
Audit	Retain prior version and citations for historical reconstruction
Monitor	Check retrieval logs for stale-version appearances

4. Emergency withdrawal

- Knowledge governance or designated safety authority can mark a source WITHDRAWN immediately.
- Remove it from eligible retrieval and invalidate relevant caches.
- Identify queries/answers that cited it during the affected period.
- Notify clinical governance and application owner; assess whether outputs require review.
- Replace only after approval, ingestion validation, and regression testing.
- Record reason, author, timestamp, affected versions, actions, and closure.

5. Conflicting and stale sources

Vector similarity, recency of ingestion, or model preference cannot resolve a source conflict. If two eligible sources materially disagree and applicability cannot be determined by deterministic metadata, return CONFLICT_REQUIRES_REVIEW.

Condition	System behavior
Review date passed	Exclude unless temporary approval is explicit
Two ACTIVE versions same ID	Stop affected retrieval and alert governance
Citation points to superseded version	Preserve historical citation but do not use for new recommendation
Source has no provenance/hash	Exclude
Jurisdiction/audience mismatch	Exclude or clearly label as non-applicable supporting information
Source correction received	Withdraw affected version; reingest corrected version; rerun evaluations

6. Retrieval audit

For every retrieved chunk record document ID, version, status, heading, page, score/rank, metadata filters, index version, retrieval timestamp, and whether it was ultimately cited.

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